



DESIGN NOTE

Officer and Soldier Leadership Development

TWO-PAGE AITC DISCUSSION PIECE: DESIGN DRAFT 4

New Zealand Army Leadership Centre | Army Command School

Reference: NZDF Leadership Framework v2 (Oct 2025); LDS, Leadership Levels and Leadership Framework posters · **Date:** September 2026 · **Status:** Design draft for approval

1. The Tasking, Reduced to Its Point

COMDT ACS asked ACS (ALC) to table a discussion piece at the AITC before end of year on how the Officer and Other Rank promotion continuums align with the intent and design of the LDF: present the facts and challenge the organisation to decide about the development of leaders at all levels. The trigger was a request to link Lead Leaders to promotion to substantive Captain.

The first design reduced the issue to a proposition: Army deliberately links leadership development and promotion within the Soldier continuum, and the equivalent relationship within the Officer continuum is less clear. On 9 September 2026 Mike and Dave walked each transition of both continuums. The transcript of that meeting is now the working evidence base; where it and the auto-generated meeting notes differ, the transcript governs. It broadly supports the proposition and gives a much better story.

The Officer side is not simply "nothing is mandated". The link between development and the career transition runs on a spectrum, from formally mandated, through functionally required, to expected or self-selected, to unconnected. The Soldier continuum sits at the formal end for its lower transitions. The Officer continuum is strong at commissioning, weakest in the operational middle, and strong again at the top. Is that shape a conscious choice?

The seven-page diagnostic and its six-category matrix remain withdrawn. The product is two pages. The current-versus-desired mapping the meeting actioned is held as an ALC working paper and is not part of the discussion piece: COMDT asked whether the difference is deliberate, and Army has not yet answered.

2. The Pages

Page 1 is the product. Page 2 is the discussion. Both are built to be understood from three metres: one status per transition, and nothing on the page that explains a cell.

Page	Purpose	What is on it
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1. Two continuums. One leadership framework.	Make the discrepancy impossible to miss	Officer continuum, common LDF spine, Soldier continuum. Every horizontal row is one LDF transition read across two career systems, and both cells sit on the same line. Each cell carries the rank transition, the course, one status (mandated, functionally required, expected, self-selected) and at most one qualifying line. Mandated cells are shaded. Headline question above; the closing line beneath.
2. Where is development deliberately linked to progression?	Show the shape, then pose the challenge	The officer continuum as a band whose thickness is the linkage level at each transition, so it narrows at CAPT to MAJ and widens again at the top. The soldier band immediately beneath as the comparator. The mechanism statement. Three short facts. Then COMDT's question, IF YES and IF NO, and stop.

Held back, as a working paper: the current-versus-desired mapping (transition, rank, course and delivery, linkage now, linkage desired). It prescribes a future state, which exceeds the tasking until Army has answered the question on page 2.

Row discipline on page 1 is the rule that makes the comparison fair: OCDT to 2LT and PTE to LCPL both sit on the Lead Self to Lead Teams line because Lead Teams is embedded in NZCC and in the JNCO course respectively; if a later check moves a rank pairing, the cell moves rows rather than the row being relabelled.

Evidence status (STATED 9 SEP, TO CONFIRM), course codes and delivery organisations are off the page. They live in the data register and in speaker notes.

The fixed wordings:

Place	Wording
Headline, page 1	How deliberately does Army link leadership development to progression through its Officer and Soldier promotion continuums?
Close, page 1	Same leadership framework. Different mechanisms for ensuring development occurs.
Statement, page 2	The issue may not be an absence of leadership development. It is the absence of a consistently deliberate mechanism linking the right development to the right career transition.
Facts, page 2	Soldiers: leadership development is deliberately embedded in key promotion pathways. Officers: equivalent development exists, but its linkage to career progression varies considerably across the continuum. The question: is that difference deliberate, and if so, what is the rationale?
Challenge, page 2	Is this a conscious choice? If yes, what is the rationale for treating Officer and Soldier leadership development differently? If no, should Army establish a more consistent mechanism for ensuring development occurs before increased leadership responsibility?

3. The Linkage Scale and the Shape of the Gap

The meeting made a binary comparison untenable. At the 2LT and LT to CAPT transition, Lead Leaders is not mandated in promotion policy, yet OCS and COs police it so that in practice no junior

officer promotes without it. That is neither "mandated" nor "not mandated". The visual language therefore changes from MANDATED? YES / NO to a scale of career linkage:

Level	State	Meaning
4	Formally mandated	In promotion policy, or embedded in the qualifying course so that qualifying on the course qualifies the leadership content
3	Functionally required	Not in policy, but policed as if it were
2	Expected	Self-selected, with high uptake
1	Self-selected	Uptake rests on individual inclination
0	Unconnected	No link between the development and the transition

Read on that scale, the officer continuum has a shape. Commissioning is structured: Lead Teams is embedded in NZCC. LT to CAPT is functionally enforced but not policy-embedded. CAPT to MAJ is the weakest point: neither ELDA nor LDS Lead Systems is mandated or policed, uptake rests on inclination, and it is the transition at which scope of influence grows most, from platoon to OC. From MAJ to LTCOL participation strengthens, and at LTCOL and above it is near-universal, because those officers are selected, scrutinised and career-conscious. Dave called the middle the grey zone: the officers doing the practical enabling and leading of Army, without the same systematic training link.

That is the emerging pattern, and page 2 is built on it. The problem is not soldiers developed and officers not. It is junior development, a hollow operational middle, and strong participation again at senior level. Strong participation at the top may also explain why senior leaders assume the same development is happening throughout Army. The page does not call it a gap or a finding: it shows the shape and asks whether it is deliberate.

4. Why the LDF Stays in the Middle

The LDF is retained as the spine because it is the common reference that makes the comparison fair. Its levels describe progressively different leadership requirements. Placing the two continuums against it allows one question to be asked at each transition: at the same developmental shift, what does Army require of a soldier, and what does it require of an officer?

Two points still govern how the spine is used.

1. **The rank mapping is an estimate.** The Leadership Levels poster says its alignment of rank to level is "only an estimation". Rank pairings on page 1 now follow the meeting (WO2 is the Lead Systems tick, WO1 the Lead Capability tick) and place the comparison; they do not assert that a rank equals a level.
2. **The LDS intends development before the transition.** The Leadership Development System places the LDS course in the Orientation phase, ideally about six months before the first posting to the new level. The meeting adds that timing is critical for officers: Lead Leaders at OCS or on commissioning was the wrong time, and the aim is to capture officers with a couple of years of unit experience.

5. What Is Known and What Is Not

Populated cells on page 1 rest on the 9 September transcript, read against the four source documents and the NZALC course data sheets. STATED 9 SEP marks a statement from the meeting not yet verified; TO CONFIRM marks a cell where a policy check is owed before the state can stand.

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Transition	Soldier	Officer
Entry	Lead Self compulsory on entry, delivered through train-the-trainer (TAD, ACS)	Lead Self compulsory, as for soldiers
T1 Lead Self to Lead Teams	PTE to LCPL. Formally mandated: ELDA Lead Teams (A18011) and LDS Lead Teams (D03020) inside the JNCO course (A1530)	OCDT to 2LT. Formally mandated through NZCC: ELDA Lead Teams (the former Nemesis, rebranded with the same learning outcomes) and LDS Lead Teams, delivered by ALC at OCS in March, two years running
T2 Lead Teams to Lead Leaders	CPL to SGT. Formally mandated: the SNCO course (A1531) carries ELDA Lead Leaders (A18008) and LDS Lead Leaders (D03030). "Very clear on the NCO front"	2LT and LT to CAPT. Functionally required: not in promotion policy, but policed by OCS and COs. "Super murky on the officer front". The substantive CAPT request. TO CONFIRM against policy
T3 Lead Leaders to Lead Systems	SSGT to WO2. Likely linked: ELDA Lead Systems (A18010) mandated on the WO course (A1532). Whether ILD LDS Lead Systems is a prerequisite for WO2 carries Dave's question mark; check the promotion-course CDS. Army cannot guarantee an ILD seat, so the course is routinely done before or after the promotion course	CAPT to MAJ. Self-selected: neither ELDA Lead Systems nor ILD LDS Lead Systems is mandated or policed; those who most need it opt out
T4 Lead Systems to Lead Capability	WO2 to WO1. Expected, high uptake: "pretty sure" not in policy; most attend, subject to an ILD seat. TO CONFIRM	MAJ to LTCOL. Expected, high uptake: not mandated; the impression is that all complete it. TO CONFIRM
T5 Lead Capability to Lead Integrated Capability	WO1s. ILD pathway: one ELDA week (ALC caving or Navy sailing) and one LDS week in Wellington, both run and funded by ILD; 12 to 16 students; attended without exception	LTCOL and COL. The same course; attended without exception
T6 Lead Integrated Capability to Lead Organisation	Senior WO1s considered for the senior appointments. LDS Lead Organisation with an ELDA component; all complete it well before they need to	COL and BRIG. The same course; all complete it well before required

Two structural facts from the meeting shape the reading of the table.

1. **The 2012 division of delivery.** Single-Service providers train Lead Self to Lead Leaders, which covers most of the organisation. ILD trains Lead Systems and above for all three Services, and Army retains the ELDA function at those levels. Army therefore cannot guarantee an ILD seat, which is why LDS Lead Systems sits outside the WO promotion course and why a mandate above T2 is harder to enforce on either continuum.
2. **Uptake above the middle is not evidence of a mandate.** At Lead Capability and above people generally complete the development, but the meeting did not establish that policy requires it. Those cells stay at "expected" until the policy check is done.

The facts still required are the same three for every transition on each side, and are listed in the accompanying register:

1. **Promotion point.** The authoritative Army promotion or career point that corresponds to the transition.
2. **Development intervention.** The course or programme that develops the individual for that transition, with its SOLO code.

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3. **Career linkage.** Where the link sits on the scale in section 3, confirmed against promotion policy or the promotion-course data sheet. For the officer side at T2 to T4 this is a check of policy against what the meeting stated, and it is the remaining hard work: the story the product tells is now settled.

6. How It Arose, and Tone

COMDT does not want an accusatory paper, and the meeting gives the history that makes one unnecessary. Intent and senior buy-in existed: AITC agreed in principle that officers should complete the development. Lead Leaders was attached to Grade 2 and 3 coursing for a two-year trial, and the additional time away from units was judged untenable. A distributed model was then preferred, leaving officers to schedule the development within their careers. Later restructuring and course redesigns proceeded without ACS at the table, so no integrated solution emerged. The Post Commissioning Programme got every junior officer through Lead Leaders, but before unit experience, which the meeting judged the wrong time.

Dave's assessment near the end was that this looks like a scheduling and implementation problem under organisational tempo rather than an intentional decision to develop officers differently: when development is not formally required, it is what gets displaced. That may be the answer to COMDT's question. It is not put forward as ALC's finding and it is not on the page. The history and the assessment are speaker notes for whoever tables the piece, so that the room does not retread old ground, and AITC is left to answer the institutional question. Both branches of the closing question are given equal weight, and no recommendation is attached.

7. What Has Been Withdrawn

1. The six-category matrix, the gap taxonomy and the seven-page sequence remain in the repository history as analytical scaffolding.
2. The binary MANDATED? boxes, the linkage meters and the evidence chips of the earlier two-page drafts. One status per cell replaces them; the evidence sits in the register.
3. The third page. The current-versus-desired mapping is an ALC working paper, not part of the discussion piece.
4. The claim of "no new courses and no new money". No new course needs designing, but whether guaranteed ILD seats and timing aligned to promotion carry a capacity or resource implication is not known. The working paper says so.
5. Any labelling of the officer pattern as a gap or a finding on the page itself.

8. Actions From the 9 September Meeting

Action	Owner	Where it lands in this product
Verify whether the ILD LDS Lead Systems course is a prerequisite in the promotion-course data sheet for SSGT to WO2	Dave	Page 1, soldier T3; register row T3-R-LINK

Check officer promotion requirements in policy for leadership training mandates at each rank	Team	Page 1, officer T2 to T4; register rows T2-O-LINK to T4-O-LINK, and X1
Develop a visual mapping of the current versus desired framework, highlighting discrepancies and critical points	Team	Pages 1 and 2 (current); the working paper (desired)
Confirm timing and scheduling of the courses at each transition and their delivery mechanism	Team	Working paper, course and delivery columns; register X3 and X6
Prepare a future-state plan: progression levels, delivery agents, policy endorsements linking training to promotion	Team	Working paper, held until AITC answers page 2